

The Snack That Screamed

Allen Girls Adventures

Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1 — Reading Hour Has Rules

The Labyrinth Library had many rules, and most of them were sensible.

No running in the cartography corridor. No whistling near the listening shelves (they would whistle back, and they would be better at it than you). No returning a book to the wrong shelf on purpose, because the library remembered that kind of thing and would move every book you needed for the next month to a different floor. These rules had been explained during orientation. They were posted on a laminated card near the main entrance. SPARK had memorized them within his first six seconds in the building and considered the laminated card an insult to his processing speed.

The rule about vending machine E-7 had not been on any laminated card.

It was a Tuesday in late October — the kind of Tuesday that smells like pencil shavings and overripe apples — when Maya discovered the rule the hard way.

She had been sitting in Reading Alcove Nine for forty-five minutes with a stack of adventure stories she had fully intended to read, and had instead been building a very impressive tower out of bookmarks. The tower was nine centimeters tall and structurally sound. She was proud of it.

Natalia was doing actual reading, which she did with the focused intensity of someone diffusing a very literary bomb. Alana had a notebook open and was writing observations about the humidity levels near the south wall, which was either a science experiment or a reason to avoid the science corner.

SPARK floated near the ceiling, monitoring ambient conditions and cataloguing the way afternoon light changed the color temperature of the shelves. He had done this forty-seven times. He enjoyed it.

The vending machine stood at the end of the alcove corridor, between a water fountain and a cork board dense with notices about overdue books. It was pale cream in color, slightly older than the rest of the library's furniture, and marked at the top with the label E-7 in block letters the same amber as the library's oldest lamps.

Maya's bookmark tower had reached its structural limit and toppled. She decided she had earned a snack.

She walked to the machine, fed in the correct coins, and pressed the button for the cheese crackers in row four.

The machine screamed.

Not the vending machine sound of mechanical disappointment — not the muffled clunk of a product stuck in its coil. A real scream. A high, theatrical, operatic shriek that bounced off every shelf in Alcove Nine and arrived at the ears of Natalia, Alana, and SPARK at exactly the same time with exactly the same effect:

Everyone dropped what they were holding.

Natalia's book. Alana's pencil. SPARK's cataloguing process.

Maya stood very still in front of the machine, her coins returned to the tray, the crackers unmoved in their slot. On the screen where prices were usually displayed, two words had appeared in green light:

YOU SKIPPED THE LABEL.

Chapter 2 — The Machine With Opinions

The coins sat in the return tray. The crackers sat in their coil. Maya stood at a careful distance from the machine and considered whether she had done something wrong.

"I pressed the right button," she said. "I definitely pressed the right button."

SPARK descended from his ceiling observation post and hovered beside her at eye level with the machine's display panel. The green letters had faded back to the usual price menu, which showed cheese crackers at ninety cents and appeared entirely innocent.

"The auditory event lasted two-point-three seconds," SPARK said. "Peak frequency was consistent with a soprano voice. Human range. Not mechanical."

Alana had retrieved her pencil and was already taking notes. "So it isn't a broken speaker."

"The machine has no speaker," SPARK said. "I've reviewed the hardware specs. The display panel generates light. The coin mechanism generates sound. Neither of them generates a scream."

Natalia was standing at the edge of the alcove with her book held to her chest, looking at the machine the way you look at something you respect slightly more than you expected to. "What did it say? On the screen — what did it say?"

"You skipped the label," Maya said. She looked at the crackers. She looked at the label on the crackers. It was small and yellow and listed ingredients in a font so tiny it required optimism. "I don't read ingredient labels on snack food."

"Most people do not," SPARK confirmed.

"Is that," Alana said carefully, "a moral failing on our part?"

Nobody answered, because from inside the machine came a sound that was not a scream. It was much worse than a scream. It was a sigh. Long, slow, deeply disappointed — the sigh of someone who had expected better and had been proven correct not to.

Maya squared her shoulders. "I'm going to try again."

She put the coins back in. She pressed the crackers button. She read the label. She read it aloud, quietly: enriched flour, vegetable oil, cheddar seasoning, salt. She pressed confirm.

The crackers dropped.

No scream.

The display screen showed a new message for three seconds before returning to prices: THANK YOU FOR YOUR ATTENTION.

"Right," Natalia said. "We need to find out what is in that machine."

"The crackers are in that machine," Maya said, already eating one.

"The other thing," Natalia said. "The thing with opinions."

Chapter 3 — Strange Things at Snack Time

The library opened at eight in the morning and Reading Alcove Nine opened with it, but the vending machine had its own hours and its own understanding of what those hours meant.

They discovered this over the following three days.

On Wednesday morning, a fourth-grade reader named Oliver pressed the button for apple juice and received it without incident. He had not screamed and the machine had not screamed and the entire transaction was unremarkable in every way except that Oliver had taken thirty seconds studying the juice label before pressing his button — he was the kind of child who read everything — and SPARK, monitoring unobtrusively from the corner, noted that the machine's display had lit up briefly in what could only be described as a pleased amber.

On Wednesday afternoon, two older students tried the chips in row seven. The first student read the bag. No scream. The second student grabbed the bag out of the tray before it had fully arrived, shook it twice to hear the contents, and ate a chip without looking at the package at all. The machine screamed so loudly that three books fell off nearby shelves.

The librarian on duty, a tall woman named Ms. Osei, came to investigate. She looked at the machine. She looked at the students. She looked at the books on the floor. She put the books back.

"E-7 is particular," she said, in a tone that suggested she had said this before. She said nothing else and returned to the circulation desk.

"She knows," Alana whispered.

"Everyone who works here seems to know," Natalia said. "They just don't explain it."

"Standard library behavior," SPARK said. "The policy appears to be: figure it out."

Maya had eaten three additional snacks from the machine by this point and had read every label with careful attention. The machine had not screamed at her again. It had, on Thursday morning, given her a bonus granola bar

without any payment and displayed the message WELL DONE on the screen for four full seconds.

"It's rewarding you," Alana said.

"It's rewarding reading," Maya said.

She looked at the bonus granola bar. She looked at the machine. The machine looked back with its dark glass panel and its amber standby light, patient and watchful and waiting, the way only things with strong opinions about correct behavior ever truly wait.

"Okay," Maya said. "I want to talk to whatever is in there. And I think I know how."

Chapter 4 — An Inventory of Clues

The investigation into vending machine E-7 began, as all good investigations do, with a list.

Alana wrote it in her field notebook under the heading OBSERVABLE FACTS, which she underlined twice because she felt the subject warranted it.

One: the machine produced screams of soprano range and human quality when users took snacks without reading the label. Two: the machine produced silence and occasional bonus items when users read the label carefully. Three: the screen showed text messages that were grammatically correct and mildly editorial in tone. Four: a long, theatrical sigh had been heard from inside the machine when Maya admitted she did not read labels. Five: librarian Ms. Osei was aware of the machine's behavior and had chosen to describe it as particular rather than haunted, broken, or alarming, which meant she considered it a personality trait rather than a malfunction.

"Let's start with the text messages," Natalia said. She had her own notebook and had been recording every message the screen had shown: YOU SKIPPED THE LABEL. THANK YOU FOR YOUR ATTENTION. WELL DONE. "They're all about reading. Specifically about reading labels. Ingredient lists."

"Ingredient lists are a type of text," SPARK said. "They communicate information in a structured, compressed format. What something contains. In what order. In what amounts."

"Like a poem," Maya said.

Everyone looked at her.

"Not exactly like a poem," she said. "But — like a list that means something. Like the order matters. Like if you skip it you miss something."

"A recipe is a list that means something," Alana said slowly. "If you skip a step, you get a different result. If you skip an ingredient, you get a different dish." She looked at the machine. "Ingredient lists tell you what went into something. If you skip it, you're eating without understanding what you're eating."

"Which is," SPARK said, "a reasonable metaphor for reading."

Natalia closed her notebook. "So whatever is in that machine cares very specifically about reading ingredient lists because it believes that is the correct way to engage with what you're consuming. It has made a food metaphor about literacy."

They all thought about this.

"That," Maya said, "is either the most deeply eccentric ghost in the history of ghosts, or it used to be a teacher."

"Not a teacher," said a voice from the machine's speaker — and this time the voice was not a scream. It was quiet, slightly muffled, and distinctly offended. "I was a poet."

Chapter 5 — The Voice From Row Six

The voice from row six spoke in the measured cadences of someone who had once been very good at performing for an audience and still remembered exactly how to pause for effect.

"A poet," it said again, with the emphasis on the second syllable.

The four of them arranged themselves in front of the machine with the careful posture of people who have decided that this situation is interesting rather than terrifying. SPARK's chest panel turned a thoughtful blue. Alana had her notebook open. Natalia was very still.

Maya said: "In the vending machine."

"Circumstances," the voice said, "placed me here."

"What circumstances?"

A long pause. The amber standby light blinked three times in a slow, deliberate rhythm that might have been a sigh made visible. "My name," the voice said, "was Edmund Quill. I was the poet in residence of the Labyrinth Library's cafeteria from nineteen eighty-three until I retired in two thousand and one. I wrote a poem for every menu item served in this building for eighteen years. Every soup. Every sandwich. Every side dish. The poems were printed on cards and placed beside the food."

"What happened to the cards?" Alana asked.

"People stopped reading them," Edmund said. "They would take the food and not look at the card. They ate the soup without reading the soup poem. They took the sandwich without reading the sandwich poem. I wrote a sonnet for the Tuesday egg salad. Nobody read the egg salad sonnet. Do you have any idea what it is to watch someone eat an egg salad sonnet?"

"Unfortunate," SPARK said diplomatically.

"Devastating," Edmund corrected. "A poem is an ingredient list, you understand. It tells you what went into a thing. What the person who made it used, and in what proportion, and why the flavors sit beside each other rather

than against each other. If you skip the poem, you eat the sandwich and you think it is just a sandwich. But you have missed what it was made of."

"And when you retired," Natalia said quietly, "you came here. To the snack machine."

"I came here," Edmund said, "to make a point."

"You've been making that point since two thousand and one?"

The amber light blinked.

"Some points," Edmund Quill said, with the dignity of someone who has never once questioned the proportionality of a response, "take time."

Chapter 6 — What Edmund Wanted

The history of Edmund Quill, as he told it between the vending machine's operational hours of eight AM and six PM, was both more elaborate and more touching than any of them had anticipated.

He had grown up in a city where the library was the only building he trusted to be colder in summer and warmer in winter than anywhere else, which is to say the library was predictable in its care. He had read everything he could reach and some things he climbed bookshelves to reach, which the librarians had tolerated because he always put the books back in better condition than he found them. He had studied poetry at university with the conviction of someone who believes words are the most precisely useful tools ever invented. He had applied for the poet-in-residence position at the Labyrinth Library's cafeteria in nineteen eighty-three because, as he explained to the hiring committee, food and poetry were the same thing: both required care about ingredients, both rewarded attention, both were wasted on people who consumed them without noticing.

The committee had hired him on the spot.

For eighteen years he had written a poem a day. The Tuesday egg salad sonnet was genuinely very good; he recited a stanza of it now and even Alana, who did not consider herself particularly interested in egg salad poetry, had to admit it was precise and surprisingly moving. He had written about lentil soup in terza rima. He had composed a villanelle for the cheese plate. He had written a haiku every single day for apple juice, because apple juice was deceptively simple and deserved the haiku form's discipline.

"And nobody read them?" Maya said.

"Some people read them," Edmund said. "The readers read them. The people who came to the cafeteria with a book already open and their minds still warm from reading — they read the cards. They would sometimes tell me which ones they liked. A girl once told me my sonnet for vegetable soup was the best thing she had ever read in a cafeteria, and I considered retiring on that compliment." A pause. "I did not retire."

"But most people didn't."

"Most people," Edmund said, "looked at the food and thought: food. They did not think: what went into this. They ate without reading. And eating without reading is —"

"Missing the point," Natalia said.

"Missing," Edmund said, with great feeling, "everything."

Chapter 7 — The Ingredient List Theory

SPARK had spent the previous night running calculations on Edmund's grievance, which he presented the next morning in the form of a diagram projected onto the back wall of Alcove Nine.

The diagram was titled PARALLEL STRUCTURES: READING AND EATING (A COMPARATIVE FRAMEWORK). It had three columns.

"Column one," SPARK said, "is what happens when you read an ingredient list. Column two is what happens when you read a poem. Column three is what happens when you read a book."

The columns were identical.

"You slow down," SPARK said. "You acknowledge that someone made a choice about every word — or every ingredient — and that the order and the combination were intentional. You bring attention. You take the thing apart to understand how it holds together. And then you experience it more completely because you know what went into it."

Edmund's machine hummed with quiet approval.

"The scream," Maya said, "is what happens when you don't do any of that."

"The scream," Edmund said through the speaker, "is the sound of an unread label. If you had ears like mine, you would hear it every time someone opened a book to the middle, or skipped the introduction, or flipped to the ending, or took a sandwich without looking at the card."

"That sounds exhausting," Alana said.

"It is very exhausting," Edmund agreed. "That is why I have opinions about it."

Natalia had been quiet through SPARK's presentation and through Edmund's explanation, sitting with her chin in her hand in the way she sat when she was solving the part of a problem that wasn't obvious yet. "Edmund," she said. "When people skipped your cafeteria poems — they weren't being cruel. They were just busy. Hungry. They didn't know the poem was important because nobody told them. Nobody said: there is a poem here, please read it, it matters."

A long pause from the machine. The amber light blinked twice.

"No," Edmund said. "No, the signs were small. I may have assumed people would look."

"And the screaming," Alana said carefully, "doesn't tell them why. It tells them they did something wrong, but not what to do instead."

The machine was quiet.

"I did," Edmund said slowly, "want to be understood."

"That's different from wanting to be heard," Maya said.

The amber light blinked once. Then twice. Then it held steady for a long moment, which was either processing or the mechanical equivalent of someone staring out a window and reconsidering things.

Chapter 8 — Alana's Proposal

It was Alana who proposed the solution, which surprised everyone including Alana.

She had been quiet for most of the previous conversation, filling her notebook with parallel columns and structural diagrams — the kind of analysis she did when a problem had clear architecture that just needed to be named. She reviewed her notes that evening and came back the next morning with a very organized plan and the expression of someone who has been awake since five AM rehearsing how to present it.

"Edmund," she said, addressing the machine directly, "you screamed at people for skipping ingredient labels because you wanted them to pay attention to what things were made of. But what you actually wanted was for people to understand that reading the label — reading anything, really — was an act of respect toward the person who made it."

The amber light blinked.

"Yes," Edmund said.

"The screaming communicated the rule without communicating the reason. So people followed the rule here, in front of this machine, but didn't understand it well enough to carry it anywhere else."

A longer pause. "That is... an accurate analysis."

"So what if instead of screaming," Alana said, "the machine showed people a poem?"

Silence from the machine.

"Your poems," she continued. "When someone takes a snack without reading the label, instead of screaming — what if the display showed three lines? A short poem. One of yours. About the snack. About what went into it. About why reading it matters."

"A haiku," SPARK said thoughtfully. "You could fit a haiku on that display."

"The apple juice haikus," Maya said at once, and she meant it sincerely.

Edmund Quill did not answer for a full minute. The machine hummed its operational hum. The ambient temperature in Alcove Nine remained steady. Outside in the corridor, a student walked past with three books stacked on their head for reasons nobody investigated.

"My poems," Edmund finally said, "have not been read by anyone since two thousand and one."

"That's a long time," Natalia said gently.

"It is a very long time," Edmund agreed. His voice had lost some of its editorial sharpness. It sounded, instead, the way the sigh had sounded on the first day — tired, and a little hopeful, which is the specific combination of feelings that comes just before something changes. "You would read them?"

"We'd start with the egg salad sonnet," Maya said.

"The egg salad sonnet," Edmund said quietly, "is really very good."

Chapter 9 — SPARK's Engineering Problem

The problem, as SPARK identified it, was hardware.

"Edmund exists in the machine as an acousto-spectral resonance," SPARK explained, which was the technical way of saying that Edmund had been in the machine for so long that he and the machine had developed a mutual understanding that bypassed conventional physics. "He can generate sounds and manipulate the display panel because those are the machine's communication systems and he has learned to use them. But reprogramming the display to show text requires an access panel, a service code, and a reasonably cooperative ghost."

"I am very cooperative," Edmund said, slightly offended.

"You screamed at a child for taking chips."

"She shook the bag without looking at the label."

"She was eleven."

"Eleven-year-olds can read labels."

Natalia intervened before this became a longer argument. "What do you need, SPARK?"

SPARK pulled up a schematic projection of the machine's internal display panel. "The display operates on a four-line character grid. It currently shows only pricing information and my error messages, which Edmund has been overriding with his own editorial commentary. If I access the service menu — which requires the code,

which Ms. Osei will have — I can add a secondary display mode that Edmund can activate. Instead of the scream, the display shows a poem. Edmund chooses which poem. Edmund presses nothing because Edmund does not have hands. But Edmund can influence the display's amber channel, as we have already seen."

"So Edmund becomes the curator," Maya said.

"Edmund has always been the curator," Edmund said, more warmly now.

They went to find Ms. Osei.

She was at the circulation desk reshelving periodicals with the brisk efficiency of someone for whom Tuesday is the same as Friday in terms of purpose. She looked at them when they arrived and then she looked at the machine at the end of the corridor and she said, in the tone of someone who has been waiting for this conversation for some time: "You met Edmund."

"We met Edmund," Natalia confirmed.

"He has been in that machine," Ms. Osei said, "since two thousand and three. He walked in looking for the cafeteria, which had been converted to a reading room in two thousand and two, and he was very displeased about the renovation." She produced a small card from beneath the desk. On it was a six-digit number. "The service code. Don't let Edmund choose the font. He has opinions about fonts."

"I have excellent taste in fonts," Edmund said from the machine at the end of the corridor, at a volume that was technically impressive from forty feet away.

Chapter 10 — The Egg Salad Sonnet

The service panel opened on the third try, which SPARK considered acceptable and Edmund considered unconscionable.

"The third try," Edmund said from the speaker above SPARK's head as SPARK worked at the access panel.

"The panel requires a specific torque on the lower-left fastener," SPARK said. "I recalibrated on the second attempt."

"In my experience," Edmund said, "things that are worth doing open on the first try."

"That is not how machines work," SPARK said.

"Metaphorically."

"I do not operate metaphorically."

Maya had positioned herself to hand SPARK tools, which she was doing with great seriousness even though SPARK mostly just needed quiet. Alana was transcribing Edmund's poems into her notebook — he had been

reciting them for forty minutes now and showed no sign of stopping, which everyone agreed was more an enthusiasm than an inconvenience. Natalia was reading the poems as Alana transcribed them and making small sounds of genuine appreciation at the better lines.

The egg salad sonnet was, in fact, very good. It was about the specific texture of egg combined with mayonnaise and how that texture was a form of comfort not despite but because of its simplicity — and how simplicity, in both food and words, took more care to achieve than complexity. The final couplet contained a line about how the best sandwiches, like the best sentences, said exactly enough and never more, and Natalia read it twice and wrote it in the margin of her notebook in slightly larger letters.

SPARK completed the display modification at two forty-seven PM.

"Activating secondary channel," he said.

The display lit up in amber — not the usual pale transactional amber but something warmer, the color of a lamp in a window. Three lines appeared, clean and evenly spaced:

Salted flour, water, yeast — *bread is a sentence waiting* *to be read with both hands.*

Alana looked up from her notebook. "Edmund."

"Bread haiku, nineteen eighty-seven," Edmund said, with the quiet satisfaction of someone who has been waiting to say a thing for a very long time and is grateful the moment has finally arrived. "Do you like it?"

"I like it," Natalia said.

"I will need you," Edmund said, "to tell me that more often."

Chapter 11 — The New Rule

Three things changed in Alcove Nine starting the following Monday.

The first was the scream. It stopped. Vending machine E-7 had not screamed at a single library visitor since SPARK installed the secondary display channel, and the absence of the scream was noticed immediately by the regular population of Reading Alcove Nine, which was the kind of population that noticed the absence of things that had previously been reliably present.

Oliver, the fourth-grader who read everything, came to the machine on Monday morning, pressed his juice button without reading the label — a lapse, he said, due to being preoccupied with a very good chapter — and instead of a scream received three lines on the display:

Apple: the original *small library. Open it —* *look what's inside.*

He read it twice. He read the juice label. He pressed confirm. He stood there for another ten seconds after the juice dropped, looking at the display, which had returned to prices. He looked like someone who had been told a joke

that was also true.

"The machine is different," he told Maya.

"The machine had a change of heart," Maya said.

The second change was Alana's notebook, which now contained thirty-seven of Edmund's poems organized by category: beverage, grain-based snack, fruit, confection, and the dedicated section she had titled MISCELLANEOUS SONNET FORMS. She had begun reading one aloud at the start of each study session in the alcove, which had started as a joke and had become, without any formal decision, a thing they did.

The third change was on the cork board beside the water fountain, where a small card had appeared in unfamiliar handwriting — not Alana's precise print, not Natalia's careful script, not Maya's enthusiastic looping letters, not SPARK's projected text. The handwriting leaned slightly to the right, as if walking uphill. It said:

Read the label. Read the poem. Read the page. *Things made with care deserve a careful eye.* *— E. Quill, poet in residence*

Below the title, someone — possibly Ms. Osei, possibly Edmund, possibly both — had added a sub-line in smaller letters: The Labyrinth Library Cafeteria, 1983–2001. Library Snack Wing, 2003–present.

Natalia stood in front of the card for a long time.

"He's still the poet in residence," she said.

"He never really stopped," SPARK said.

From the machine, a soft amber hum. Not a scream. Not even a sigh. Just the warm operational note of a machine that had found, after a very long wait, its correct purpose.

Chapter 12 — What the Labels Said

The Labyrinth Library had a tradition, unremarked on its laminated orientation card, of telling you what it needed from you without telling you it was telling you.

The warm stone door that said REMEMBER. The brass meridian line that appeared only when someone measured carefully enough. The vending machine that screamed, and then stopped screaming, and then began leaving small poems for anyone who bought a snack on a Tuesday afternoon and thought to look.

Natalia wrote about Edmund in her observations notebook, where she kept records of the library's living things — the books that moved on their own, the lamps that stayed on after hours, the shelf that reorganized itself based on what you'd read last week. She wrote: E-7 is a teaching machine. It teaches the thing that the library has always taught, which is that attention is not optional. That reading is a practice, and practices require repetition. That the person who made the thing — the food, the poem, the book — put themselves into the order of its components, and skipping that order is like arriving at a sentence through the middle.

Alana's notebook section on Edmund had grown to fifty-one poems. She had organized them into a small pamphlet format, printed on the library's duplicator with Ms. Osei's permission, and placed a copy in the snack alcove's free-take basket beside the reading guides. The pamphlet was titled: AN ANNOTATED SELECTION FROM THE COLLECTED WORKS OF EDMUND QUILL, POET IN RESIDENCE. It had a small illustration of a vending machine on the cover, which Maya had drawn, and which looked more like a very cheerful robot than a vending machine but which Edmund said he found flattering.

Edmund himself had become somewhat less inclined to describe his situation as tragic. He had poems being read again — thirty to forty people a day, by Alana's count — and he had four regular readers who came to the alcove specifically to hear a new poem each visit, and he had Oliver, who had taken to reviewing the display messages in a small unofficial journal he kept in his coat pocket.

"Edmund," Maya said one Thursday, eating her crackers in front of the machine with the bag label read and respectfully acknowledged, "are you happy?"

A pause. The amber light.

"I am," Edmund Quill said, with the precision of a man who had spent forty years choosing words carefully and was not about to stop now, "in a very good chapter."

SPARK's chest panel turned a warm, steady gold.

Natalia smiled.

Alana wrote it down.

Maya ate another cracker, and this time she read about it first.